ECLIPSED

Game Design Document — v0.2

Confidential / Working Draft

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1. Vision Statement

ECLIPSED is a tactical action RPG in which the player unknowingly plays both sides of a war for a kingdom's soul. The game's central dramatic irony — that the hero and the villain are the same person, fractured by an eclipse — builds silently across two acts before collapsing in a mid-game revelation that recontextualizes every decision the player has made.

The experience asks: *If you were your own worst enemy, would you recognize yourself?*

Core design philosophy: The game never judges the player. It only remembers. Every action — however it is framed by the environment — leaves a trace in the world. Costs are revealed through absence, never through warning.

Genre: Tactical Action RPG / Open-Choice World Builder **Engine:** Godot 4 **Target Platform:** PC (Steam), with console ports post-launch **Target Runtime:** 2–3 hours (single playthrough) **Replayability:** High — second playthrough is a fundamentally different experience with full dramatic awareness

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2. Core Concept

The Central Loop

The game is divided into three acts:

- **Act One:** The player controls a single merged character — a kingdom guardian of ambiguous but balanced nature. The world feels whole. Combat is tactical and deliberate. The tone is mysterious but grounded.
- **The Eclipse:** A total solar eclipse fractures the character. The player wakes as someone else, somewhere else. No explanation. No melodrama. The world feels subtly wrong.
- **Acts Two & Three:** Day and night alternate. The player controls the Dawnkeeper during the day, the Ashen during the night. Both characters move through the same world and can do anything to it — build, destroy, consume, protect. The environmental framing guides them in opposite directions, but the player's agency is total. As the two characters converge geographically, what each has built (or destroyed) becomes visible to the other.
- **The Convergence:** The two characters meet. The player realizes they have been playing against themselves.

The Dramatic Engine

The game's power comes from **dramatic irony over time**. The player should suspect the truth before the game confirms it. Clues are planted throughout Acts Two and Three: similar handwriting in journals, enemies who seem to recognize you, NPCs who react with confusion rather than hostility. The reveal is not a twist delivered by the narrative — it is a truth the player arrives at alone.

The Framing Is the Lie

Both characters have full freedom of action at all times. The environment does not restrict — it persuades:

- During the day, warm music plays, NPCs smile, the light is golden. Good actions are easy and rewarded visibly. Destructive actions are possible but the aesthetic makes them feel discordant.
- During the night, the world is hungry. Growth requires consumption. NPCs have different sprites — less readable as individuals. The game offers power and does not always tell you what it costs.

A player who kills an NPC during the day produces the same world-state outcome as the Ashen consuming one at night. The difference is entirely in how it was framed. The game never acknowledges this. The world just reflects it.

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3. Story & Structure

Act One — The Whole Self

Duration: ~35 minutes

The player awakens as the **Eclipsed One**, a guardian of the kingdom of Varath. The kingdom is under pressure from a nameless blight creeping in from the borders — darkness that warps the land and corrupts its people.

The Eclipsed One is poised, deliberate, and strangely melancholic. NPCs treat them with reverence and a faint unease. The player explores, begins building their first settlement outpost, completes tactical encounters, and starts to understand the world.

Act One ends on the night of a total solar eclipse. The player is standing in the kingdom's central square when the light fails. The screen dims. There is no cutscene, no dramatic music sting. The player's character kneels. The eclipse passes. The player wakes up.

They are somewhere else.

Act Two — The Split

Duration: ~45 minutes

Day sequences: The player wakes as the **Dawnkeeper** — bathed in morning light, surrounded by grateful NPCs, gentle music rising. Their apparent mission: protect the villages of the Varath borderlands, grow their settlements, push back the blight. Every act of settlement-building visibly expands the Dawnkeeper's warm light radius outward.

Night sequences: The player wakes as the **Ashen** — in silence and fog, surrounded by NPCs with different faces. Their apparent mission: grow stronger, expand their reach. Growth requires consumption. Some costs are shown upfront. Others are not.

The world is the same. The framing is opposite. The outcomes accumulate into the same ledger.

Planted clues in Act Two:

- A child in a Dawnkeeper-rescued village mentions "the shadow figure" who came the night before
- The Ashen finds a building the Dawnkeeper constructed — but the Ashen has never been here before
- Consuming an NPC at night who had a name in the day sequence — the name is not shown until the Dawnkeeper returns and finds only their empty home

Act Three — Convergence

Duration: ~40 minutes

The two halves of the world begin to physically connect. Settlements the Dawnkeeper built appear as corrupted shells in Ashen sequences — or are simply gone, if the Ashen consumed their population. Structures the Ashen

raised in the night appear as ruins at dawn, their purpose illegible to the Dawnkeeper.

The player knows before the characters do. The settlements tell the story.

The Convergence: The two characters approach the central square from opposite directions. The visual layers fully overlap. The screen splits, then merges. The player sees both characters from above.

They are the same person. The kingdom they built — and consumed — is the same kingdom.

The Ending (three variants, shaped by the cumulative world-state):

1. **Integration** — The influence radii of both characters have grown in rough balance. Settlements exist on both sides, each with a different texture of health. The two halves reunite. The kingdom is neither purely saved nor purely changed — it is transformed. Whole, but marked.
2. **Dominance** — One character's influence significantly outgrew the other's. That half subsumes the other. The player watches their "other self" fade. The kingdom survives under one nature.
3. **Dissolution** — Both characters have consumed more than they built. The settlement network is sparse. The influence radii barely reach the center. The Eclipsed One cannot reform from so little. The kingdom is left unmade.

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4. Characters

The Eclipsed One (Act One only)

The merged form. Deliberate, watchful. Balanced combat. Builds the first settlement outpost — the seed that both halves will grow from (or strip for parts) after the split. Speaks rarely. When they do, their words can be read two ways.

The Dawnkeeper (Day — Acts Two & Three)

The "light" framing. Guided toward protection and construction by every aesthetic cue available. Warm tones, structured armor, morning light, gentle music that becomes richer as settlements grow.

Has full freedom of action. Can burn villages, kill NPCs, take without giving. The game does not make this feel heroic — but it does not punish it either. Silence where warmth was expected is the only signal.

Does not remember the night.

The Ashen (Night — Acts Two & Three)

The "shadow" framing. Guided toward consumption and expansion by the world's hunger. Cool tones, asymmetric silhouette, unreliable light. NPCs are less readable as individuals — more readable as resources, without the game ever stating this.

Has full freedom of action. Can choose not to consume. Can build settlements of a different kind. The game does not reward restraint differently — but the world reflects it.

Does not remember the day.

Supporting Cast (Shared, Recontextualized)

- **Maret, the Elder of the first village** — Dawnkeeper: grateful survivor and settlement anchor. Ashen: gatekeeper hoarding resources. She is the same person. Her fate, if the Ashen acts on their framing, appears to the Dawnkeeper as an empty chair in a house with no smoke from its chimney.
- **The Silent Soldier** — Enemy commander in Dawnkeeper sequences, loyal lieutenant in Ashen sequences. Same model. Different sigil. If one side destroys them, the other simply never encounters them — no explanation given.
- **The Child** — The only NPC who seems to recognize both characters. Different sprite at night, same eyes. Never says anything that directly confirms recognition. The player notices.

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5. World & Setting

Varath — The Kingdom

A medieval-fantasy kingdom in late-autumn light. Stone villages on elevated platforms, forests in mid-ground, distant mountains behind. Grounded, melancholic, worn.

Day Varath: Amber light, long shadows, populated. Smoke from chimneys. NPCs visible and individually named.

Night Varath: Deep blue-grey, fog in the lowlands, quieter. The same locations read differently — not destroyed by default, but emptied. Resources visible where people were.

World Structure (No Map)

The world does not present the player with a map. Navigation is spatial and intuitive — oriented through landmarks, settlement positions, and the direction of influence spread. This is intentional: the world should feel slightly uncertain after the eclipse. A map would grant a god's-eye view that neither character should have.

Three zones exist structurally but are never labeled:

1. **The Outer Settlements** — Act One and early Act Two. First places built up or consumed. Most visible evidence of player choices.
2. **The Midlands** — Where the two characters' territories begin to approach each other. Evidence of both: a Dawnkeeper watchtower beside an Ashen extraction site, neither acknowledging the other.

3. **The Central Square** — The eclipse point and convergence. The only location that exists identically in both layers, unchanged.

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6. Gameplay Systems

Core Combat Philosophy

Tactical and deliberate — not twitch-based. Small-scale skirmishes (3–6 enemies) designed around spatial and positional logic. No grinding; encounters are finite by design.

Shared mechanics:

- **Action Points (AP):** Budget of actions per turn. Movement, attack, and abilities each cost AP.
- **Positioning:** High ground, flanking, and chokepoints create meaningful choices.

Dawnkeeper abilities:

- **Shield Wall:** Defensive formation redirecting enemy attention; absorbs hits for adjacent NPCs.
- **Rally:** Restore AP to a damaged ally.
- **Counter-stance:** Next incoming attack triggers a counter with bonus damage.

Ashen abilities:

- **Unravel:** Remove a buff, formation bonus, or positional advantage from an enemy.
- **Fade:** Become untargetable for one action; pass through enemy lines.
- **Fracture:** Debuff that amplifies the next source of damage received.

Total Player Freedom

Both characters can perform any action against any entity at any time. The game enforces nothing morally.

What the game does: frames actions aesthetically (music, lighting, NPC presentation), records what happened without comment, and reveals costs later through absence.

What the game never does: play a negative sting when you do something destructive in daylight, show a morality meter or karma tracker, have NPCs lecture the player, or distinguish mechanically between intentional and accidental harm.

The Overlap System (Act Three)

Ghost traces of the other character's world bleed into the current one:

- **Ghost structures:** Faint outlines of the other character's settlements — visual only, no physics interaction.
- **Echo NPCs:** Translucent figures where the other character's population lived. If consumed or killed, the echo is simply absent.
- **Convergence pressure:** The closer the characters geographically, the more AP-expensive certain actions become.

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7. The Influence System

The primary progression spine, replacing traditional leveling.

How Influence Works

Both characters emit an **influence radius** — a visual aura extending from their position and from every settlement they control. As influence spreads, new areas become accessible, new encounters activate, and the world visually shifts toward the dominant character in any given zone.

Dawnkeeper influence: Warm amber-gold light. Areas under it have visible NPC activity, functional structures, daytime ambience.

Ashen influence: Cool blue-grey phosphorescence. Areas under it are quieter, resources more abundant, structures functional but emptied of warmth.

Growing Influence

Influence grows through settlement actions, not combat:

- **Building:** Constructing a new outpost, watchtower, or gathering hall extends the radius.
- **Upgrading:** Improving a settlement deepens the radius and unlocks new encounter types.
- **Population growth:** NPCs that survive and remain passively grow influence over time.
- **Consumption (Ashen):** Consuming an NPC provides a burst of immediate influence at the cost of the settlement's long-term growth potential. A depleted settlement cannot expand further.

Hidden Costs

Some influence actions have costs not disclosed at the moment of choice:

- Building with "found materials" (looted from a nearby home) expands the radius — but that home is empty when the other character visits.
- The Ashen's Nourishment ability displays the influence gain immediately; it does not display that the village's growth cap has been reduced.

- Accepting help from a neutral NPC faction shifts their alignment, making them hostile to the other character. This is not disclosed.

The player can reason backward from consequences if they're paying attention. The game rewards attentiveness, not caution.

Influence at Convergence

In Act Three, the two influence radii overlap spatially, creating a contested zone — neither fully amber nor fully blue-grey, but a shifting interference pattern. In this zone, both characters feel convergence pressure and settlement functions degrade. The contested visual is the game's most explicit signal that something is wrong with the premise of two separate characters.

The size and distribution of each character's influence at convergence is the primary driver of which ending triggers.

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8. Art Direction

Visual Style

3D world with a shifted top-down perspective — approximately 60–70° camera angle. Organic depth without full 3D navigation complexity. Reference: Hades (2020), Octopath Traveler field view.

Parallax layers (4 planes):

1. **Foreground:** Character and immediate terrain. Full detail, full lighting response.
2. **Midground:** Environmental objects, NPCs, structures. Settlement upgrades are visually distinct.
3. **Background:** Treelines, hills, distant buildings. Soft parallax shift on camera movement.
4. **Sky/Atmosphere:** Dynamic. The primary differentiator between day and night and the primary carrier of influence state.

Lighting as Narrative

- **Act One:** Golden-hour light. Warm but fading. The light of something that won't last.
- **Dawnkeeper sequences:** Morning to afternoon. Clean directional light. Shadows legible and predictable.
- **Ashen sequences:** Dusk to deep night. Light sources localized and unreliable. Influence glow is the primary illumination.
- **Act Three:** The two lighting schemes bleed into each other. In convergence zones, neither palette fully resolves.

NPC Visual Design: Day vs Night

NPCs have two sprite states. This is the single most important aesthetic decision in the game:

- **Day sprites:** Individual, readable. Named characters with distinct silhouettes. They feel like people.
- **Night sprites:** Still humanoid and navigable, but subtly less individual — something about them is less legible as a person.

The night sprites should not read as "evil NPCs." They should read as people seen through a different lens. The point is that the lens is the problem, not the people.

Settlement Visual Language

- **Dawnkeeper settlements:** Layered warm stone, visible inhabitants, light from windows, ambient sound.
- **Ashen settlements:** Same base geometry, cooler palette, reduced NPC count, faint phosphorescent glow at edges — beautiful in a way that is hard to articulate as wrong.
- **Contested / destroyed settlements:** Base geometry intact. No inhabitants. No light. No glow. Just the structure, standing.

Character Visual Design

Dawnkeeper and Ashen should read as completely different on first viewing; structurally identical on second. Same silhouette, mirrored details, shared proportion. The reveal works retroactively on the art.

UI Design

Minimal and non-intrusive:

- **AP counter:** Styled per character — geometric/structured for Dawnkeeper, organic/scattered for Ashen.
- **Influence radius:** Visible as world lighting, never as a HUD ring or meter.
- **Settlement status:** Shown through physical state, never through a popup or number.

No morality meter. No alignment display. No "Quest Completed" notification.

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9. Technical Architecture (Godot 4)

Scene Structure

```
Main
├── WorldManager        # Day/night state, zone transitions, shared world state
├── CharacterController  # Shared base; Dawnkeeper and Ashen extend it
├── CombatSystem        # Turn/AP resolution, positioning grid
```

```
├── InfluenceSystem      # Settlement registry, radius calculation, overlap detection
├── OverlapSystem        # Act Three ghost rendering and convergence pressure
├── NarrativeManager     # Silent tracking of all player choices, ending calculation
├── UILayer              # Minimal HUD, styled per active character
└── AudioManager         # Adaptive music responding to influence state
```

Dual-World Technical Approach

One scene, two render layers, one shared world state:

- Day/night transition is a lighting swap and layer visibility toggle — no loading.
- NPC and settlement state is shared — actions in one layer are reflected in the other without scripted events.
- Ghost overlap in Act Three is architecturally natural: the inactive layer becomes partially visible.

Influence System Architecture

```
SettlementNode
├── base_radius         # Set at construction
├── population_count    # NPCs attached to this settlement
├── upgrade_level       # 0–3, multiplies radius
├── depletion_flag      # Set when consumption reduces population to 0
└── influence_type      # DAWN | ASHEN | CONTESTED | EMPTY
```

The player's personal radius extends from character position and is separate from settlement radii. Both are summed for zone influence calculations.

Hidden Cost Implementation

Hidden costs use **deferred state changes** — consequence is written to world state immediately but visual reveal is delayed until the affected location is visited:

1. Player action triggers immediate reward (influence gain, AP, ability)
2. World state records the cost (NPC removed, settlement cap reduced, faction shifted)
3. Cost becomes visible only when the player or other character visits the affected node

No feedback at the moment of cost. Only discovery.

Save System

Single save slot. The game silently tracks: complete world state history, influence radius sizes at each act boundary, consumption vs. construction ratio per character, geographic convergence progress. All feed into ending calculation. Nothing displayed to player.

Recommended Stack

- **Godot 4.x** with GDScript
- **Blender** — 3D environment and character assets
- **Aseprite or Krita** — NPC sprites (day/night variants), UI
- **FMOD or Godot built-in** — adaptive audio; music responds to influence state, not player morality

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10. Scope & Milestones

Phase 0 — Prototype (4–6 weeks)

- [ ] Camera rig at correct angle with 4-layer parallax
- [ ] CharacterController with AP movement and one attack
- [ ] One test settlement (build action, population count, radius visual)
- [ ] Day/night layer switch working architecturally
- [ ] One NPC with day/night sprite states

Gate: Does the camera feel right? Does the influence radius feel like territory when it expands?

Phase 1 — Vertical Slice (8–10 weeks)

- [ ] Act One fully playable (~15 minutes)
- [ ] Eclipse transition
- [ ] One Dawnkeeper sequence and one Ashen sequence — same zone, different framing
- [ ] Maret with day/night sprites and recontextualized dialogue
- [ ] One hidden cost demonstrated: Ashen consumes Maret; Dawnkeeper returns to find her gone, no explanation

Gate: Does the hidden cost land emotionally? Does the day/night framing feel genuinely different without being heavy-handed?

Phase 2 — Alpha (12–14 weeks)

- [ ] Full Act Two content
- [ ] Influence system fully implemented — both characters building outward
- [ ] Overlap System rough pass
- [ ] Three ending paths calculating correctly from world state
- [ ] All NPC sprite variants complete

Gate: When do playtesters start to suspect? Should be late Act Two.

Phase 3 — Beta (8–10 weeks)

- [ ] Act Three complete including convergence zone
- [ ] All three endings fully realized
- [ ] Adaptive music (same melody, two arrangements, bleeding at convergence)
- [ ] 8–10 blind playtests

Gate: Does the reveal land? Is the influence radius comparison at convergence visually legible without explanation?

Phase 4 — Polish & Ship (4–6 weeks)

- [ ] Final balance pass on influence growth rates
- [ ] Accessibility options (colorblind modes for influence colors, combat speed, font scaling)
- [ ] Steam page and trailer
- [ ] Press / influencer build

Appendix: Open Questions

1. **Voiceover?** Silent protagonists let the player project. Defer decision until after Phase 1 vertical slice — the answer may become clear from play.
2. **New Game+?** Second playthrough with full knowledge is potentially the best version of this game. Build the architecture to support it from the start.
3. **The Ashen's ideology.** They believe something — something the Dawnkeeper would recognize as a genuine grievance if they could hear it. Neither half has the full picture. This needs grounding before Alpha.
4. **The Child.** Same eyes, day and night. Whatever they know should be expressible without dialogue — through behavior and positioning alone.
5. **Music identity.** Same melody, two arrangements. Detectable by an attentive ear in Act Two. Undeniable at convergence.
6. **What does the Ashen build?** Extraction structures, hollow settlements. But they should be beautiful in their own way — not just dark. The game does not editorialize about which kind of settlement is correct.

Document maintained by: [Your Name] Last updated: March 2026 Next review: After Phase 0 prototype gate